
Networks of the "Social Question": Republican and Catholic Reformers in Belle Époque France (1890-1920)

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Abstract

The research concerns itself with previously unacknowledged interactions between Catholic and republican reformers in the French Third Republic before the Great War. It seeks to use network analysis to prove and subsequently examine these connections.

In a context of construction of mass democracy (Duclert 2021), the cleavage between the secularism of the emerging republican elites and French Catholicism – both in its clerical and in its lay forms – proved an extremely lively one, constituting one of the main axes of polarization of French society. In this context, the field of social reform constituted an exception. Sociological and historical studies have pointed out, first, that a politically transversal field of social reform developed in French society, driven by the need for professionalization of various new expert figures (Topalov 1999). Second, that the relevant institutions were often "porous", i.e. provided opportunity to experts of different ideological and religious persuasions (Horne 2002).

Building on previous scholarship (Ponson 1979; Durand 2006; Fabre 2019; Bruant 2007), I reconstruct the networks of two institutions of social reform: the Catholic *Semaines Sociales de France* and the republican *Collège Libre de Sciences Sociales*. My archival work will construct a database of the figures associated with these two institutions. Once this database has been completed, my task will be that of verifying the extent of the overlap between these two networks, both in order to add a quantitative dimension to my work and to select relevant case studies on which to conduct qualitative analysis.

I will present the archival material already collected and look for feedback on two counts. First, how to organize my database and how to classify the information so that network connections may emerge clearly from it. Second, what type of software might help me in organizing my data and visualizing it convincingly.

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